Middle East Technical University
Department of Electrical and Electronics Engineering

EE201 – Circuit Theory I

Lecture 11: Node Voltage Analysis

M. Mert Ankaralı

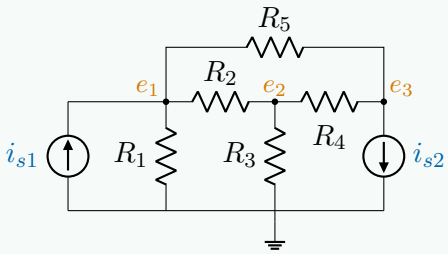
Colour code used in these notes and in the slides		
current i	voltage v, node voltage e	supernode, nodes Ⓢ

Motivation. So far, circuits were solved by simplifying them. Simplifying fundamentally changes the circuit; that is its whole point. To find the quantities of the original circuit, we must go back step by step, and some circuits cannot be simplified at all. **Node voltage analysis** works on the original circuit, without changing it. It works for every LTI resistive circuit; voltage sources need small additions, such as the supernode. Its unknowns are only the $n-1$ node voltages; every branch voltage and current follows from them. Mesh current analysis comes later.

1. The procedure, on an example

For now, the circuit has only resistors and independent current sources; voltage sources and dependent sources come later. The circuit of Example 11.1 has $b = 7$ branches, so 14 branch voltages and currents. Node voltage analysis needs only 3 unknowns. Four steps find them.

Example 11.1 — node voltage analysis step by step



1. **Reference node.** Choose the bottom node as the ground; its node voltage is 0.
2. **Node voltages.** Label the others e_1, e_2, e_3. Every branch voltage is a difference of them ($v_{R_2} = e_1 - e_2$), so KVL holds automatically.
3. **Currents.** The current leaving node k through R to node j is $(e_k - e_j)/R$; to the ground, e_k/R.
4. **KCL** at every node except the ground:

$$\text{node 1:} \quad -i_{s1} + \frac{e_1}{R_1} + \frac{e_1 - e_2}{R_2} + \frac{e_1 - e_3}{R_5} = 0$$

$$\text{node 2:} \quad \frac{e_2 - e_1}{R_2} + \frac{e_2}{R_3} + \frac{e_2 - e_3}{R_4} = 0$$

$$\text{node 3:} \quad \frac{e_3 - e_2}{R_4} + \frac{e_3 - e_1}{R_5} + i_{s2} = 0$$

The source i_{s1} points into node 1, so it enters with a minus sign. Three equations, three unknowns; then Steps 2 and 3 give every branch voltage and current.

In general, $\mathbf{v} = A^T\mathbf{e}$ (KVL holds automatically), the element laws give $\mathbf{i}$, and KCL $A\mathbf{i} = \mathbf{0}$ gives $n-1$ equations in the $n-1$ node voltages.

2. Matrix form

With $G_k = 1/R_k$ and the terms collected, the three equations of Example 11.1 become

$$\underbrace{\begin{bmatrix} G_1+G_2+G_5 & -G_2 & -G_5 \\ -G_2 & G_2+G_3+G_4 & -G_4 \\ -G_5 & -G_4 & G_4+G_5 \end{bmatrix}}_{Y_n} \underbrace{\begin{bmatrix} e_1 \\ e_2 \\ e_3 \end{bmatrix}}_{\mathbf{e}} = \underbrace{\begin{bmatrix} i_{s1} \\ 0 \\ -i_{s2} \end{bmatrix}}_{\mathbf{i}_s}.$$

Y_n is the **node admittance matrix**, and $Y_n\mathbf{e} = \mathbf{i}_s$ are the **node equations**. For a circuit of resistors and current sources, they can be written down directly.

Writing Y_n directly from the circuit: three rules

- **Diagonal** entry (k,k): the sum of the conductances connected to node k.
- **Off-diagonal** entry (k,j): minus the sum of the conductances between nodes k and j.
- **Right side**, row k: the sum of the source currents entering node k.

So Y_n is **symmetric**: the entry (k,j) equals the entry (j,k).

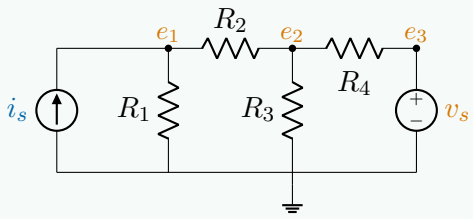
Why is Y_n symmetric? Split the columns of A into the resistor branches and the current source branches, $A = [\,A_R \quad A_S\,]$. KCL reads $A_R\mathbf{i}_R + A_S\mathbf{i}_S = \mathbf{0}$. The resistors obey $\mathbf{i}_R = G\,\mathbf{v}_R$ with $G = \mathrm{diag}(G_1,\ldots,G_5)$, and KVL gives $\mathbf{v}_R = A_R^T\mathbf{e}$. Together,

$$\underbrace{A_R\,G\,A_R^T}_{Y_n}\,\mathbf{e} = \underbrace{-A_S\mathbf{i}_S}_{\mathbf{i}_s}, \qquad Y_n^T = A_R\,G^T\,A_R^T = A_R\,G\,A_R^T = Y_n,$$

since G is diagonal. $A_S\mathbf{i}_S$ adds up the source currents leaving each node, so $-A_S\mathbf{i}_S$ adds up those entering it.

3. A voltage source to the ground

Example 11.2 — a voltage source between node 3 and the ground



The unknowns are e_1, e_2, e_3, so three equations are needed. KCL at nodes 1 and 2:

$$\text{node 1:} \quad -i_s + \frac{e_1}{R_1} + \frac{e_1 - e_2}{R_2} = 0$$

$$\text{node 2:} \quad \frac{e_2 - e_1}{R_2} + \frac{e_2}{R_3} + \frac{e_2 - e_3}{R_4} = 0$$

Question. What does KCL at node 3 give?

Answer. The current through v_s is unknown, and it cannot be written with node voltages. So KCL at node 3 gives no useful equation in e_1, e_2, e_3. But the source gives $e_3 = v_s$: this is the third equation.

Remark: a voltage source to the ground

If an independent voltage source v_s is connected between the ground and node k, then $e_k = v_s$ is known. So e_k is not an unknown, and KCL is not written at node k.

Example 11.2, revisited

The unknowns are only e_1 and e_2. Put $e_3 = v_s$ into the two KCL equations:

$$\begin{bmatrix} \frac{1}{R_1} + \frac{1}{R_2} & -\frac{1}{R_2} \\ -\frac{1}{R_2} & \frac{1}{R_2} + \frac{1}{R_3} + \frac{1}{R_4} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} e_1 \\ e_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} i_s \\ v_s/R_4 \end{bmatrix}.$$

The known v_s moves to the right side: v_s/R_4 acts like a current into node 2.

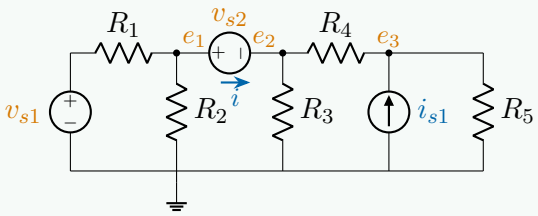
4. A voltage source between two nodes: modified node analysis

If a voltage source (independent or dependent) lies between two nodes and neither is the ground, KCL there needs its current. Its law fixes its voltage, not its current, so this current cannot be written with node voltages. **Modified node analysis** offers two ways out.

Method I

Let the unknown current i through the voltage source be one more unknown. Write KCL at every node except the ground, and add the law of the source as a **constraint equation**.

Example 11.3 — Method I



The top of v_{s1} is at the known voltage v_{s1}; v_{s2} is between nodes 1 and 2. Unknowns: e_1, e_2, e_3 and i.

node 1: $\dfrac{e_1 - v_{s1}}{R_1} + \dfrac{e_1}{R_2} + i = 0$

node 2: $-i + \dfrac{e_2}{R_3} + \dfrac{e_2 - e_3}{R_4} = 0$

node 3: $\dfrac{e_3 - e_2}{R_4} - i_{s1} + \dfrac{e_3}{R_5} = 0$

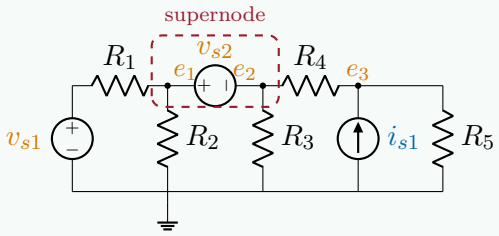
constraint: $e_1 - e_2 = v_{s2}$

$$\begin{bmatrix} G_1+G_2 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & G_3+G_4 & -G_4 & -1 \\ 0 & -G_4 & G_4+G_5 & 0 \\ 1 & -1 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} e_1 \\ e_2 \\ e_3 \\ i \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} G_1 v_{s1} \\ 0 \\ i_{s1} \\ v_{s2} \end{bmatrix}$$

Method II: the supernode

Write KCL as if the two nodes of the voltage source were a single node, a **supernode**. Add the law of the source as a constraint equation.

Example 11.3, revisited — Method II, three unknowns



supernode: $\dfrac{e_1 - v_{s1}}{R_1} + \dfrac{e_1}{R_2} + \dfrac{e_2}{R_3} + \dfrac{e_2 - e_3}{R_4} = 0$

node 3: $\dfrac{e_3 - e_2}{R_4} - i_{s1} + \dfrac{e_3}{R_5} = 0$

constraint: $e_1 - e_2 = v_{s2}$

Why does it work? Add the KCL equations of nodes 1 and 2 in Method I: i leaves node 1 and enters node 2, so it cancels. The sum is KCL around the supernode. The current i is no longer needed. In matrix form, with three unknowns and three equations:

$$\begin{bmatrix} G_1+G_2 & G_3+G_4 & -G_4 \\ 0 & -G_4 & G_4+G_5 \\ 1 & -1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} e_1 \\ e_2 \\ e_3 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} G_1 v_{s1} \\ i_{s1} \\ v_{s2} \end{bmatrix}.$$

The matrix is no longer symmetric.

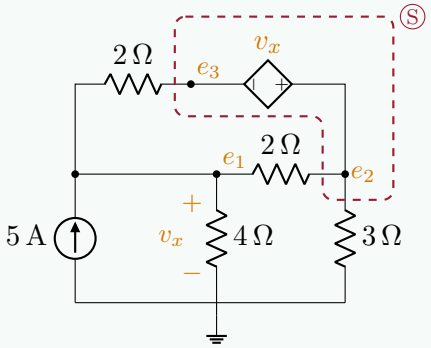
	Method I	**Method II**
extra unknown	the current i of the source	none
KCL written	at every non-ground node	at the supernode and the other nodes
extra equation	the constraint (law of the source)	the same constraint
size in Example 11.3	4×4	3×3
the current i	part of the solution	from a KCL afterwards

Both methods give the same node voltages.

5. Dependent sources

A dependent source is treated like an independent source of the same kind. Its control variable is written with node voltages; this gives one more constraint equation.

Example 11.4 — a dependent voltage source



Question. Find the power absorbed by the 3 Ω resistor.
The source v_x is between nodes 3 and 2, and neither is the ground. So use a supernode Ⓢ around nodes 2 and 3. The unknowns are e_1, e_2, e_3.

$$\text{(1) node 1:}\quad -5+\frac{e_1-e_3}{2}+\frac{e_1}{4}+\frac{e_1-e_2}{2}=0$$

$$\text{(2) Ⓢ:}\quad \frac{e_3-e_1}{2}+\frac{e_2-e_1}{2}+\frac{e_2}{3}=0$$

Constraint. The source gives $e_2-e_3=v_x$, and its control v_x is the voltage of the 4 Ω, so $v_x=e_1$:

$$e_2-e_3=e_1. \qquad (3)$$

Solving Example 11.4. Put $e_1=e_2-e_3$ into (1) and (2):

$$\tfrac{5}{4}e_1-\tfrac{1}{2}e_2-\tfrac{1}{2}e_3=5 \;\Rightarrow\; \tfrac{3}{4}e_2-\tfrac{7}{4}e_3=5, \qquad -e_1+\tfrac{5}{6}e_2+\tfrac{1}{2}e_3=0 \;\Rightarrow\; e_3=\tfrac{1}{9}e_2.$$

Then $\frac{3}{4}e_2-\frac{7}{36}e_2=\frac{20}{36}e_2=5$, so $e_2=9\,\text{V}$, $e_3=1\,\text{V}$ and $e_1=8\,\text{V}$. The 3 Ω is between node 2 and the ground:

$$P_{3\Omega}=\frac{{e_2}^2}{3}=\frac{9^2}{3}=27\,\text{W}.$$

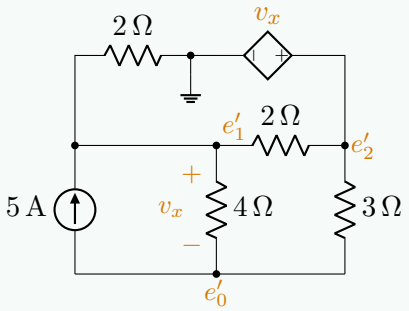
Remark: a dependent voltage source to the ground

If a dependent voltage source is connected between node k and the ground, do not write KCL at node k: its current is not known. Write the constraint that the dependent source gives instead.

6. Choosing a different ground

Any node can be the ground. Changing it shifts every node voltage by the same amount, so the branch voltages, the currents and the powers do not change.

Example 11.5 — Example 11.4 with node 3 as the ground



Question. Redo Example 11.4 with node 3 as the ground. Does the answer change?
Now v_x is between node 2 and the ground: no supernode is needed, and by the remark above, KCL is not written at node 2. The unknowns are e'_1, e'_2 and e'_0, the voltage of the old ground.

$$\text{node 1:}\quad -5+\frac{e'_1}{2}+\frac{e'_1-e'_0}{4}+\frac{e'_1-e'_2}{2}=0$$

$$\text{node 0:}\quad 5+\frac{e'_0-e'_1}{4}+\frac{e'_0-e'_2}{3}=0$$

$$\text{constraint:}\quad e'_2=v_x=e'_1-e'_0$$

Solving Example 11.5. Put the constraint into the two KCL equations: $3e_1' + e_0' = 20$ and $-7e_1' + 11e_0' = -60$. So $e_1' = 7\,\text{V}$, $e_0' = -1\,\text{V}$, $e_2' = 8\,\text{V}$, and

$$P_{3\Omega} = \frac{(e_2' - e_0')^2}{3} = \frac{9^2}{3} = 27\,\text{W}, \quad \text{the same.}$$

Every node voltage dropped by $e_3 = 1\,\text{V}$: $8 \to 7$, $9 \to 8$, $0 \to -1$.

Tip. Put the ground at one end of a voltage source. Then its other node voltage is known, or a supernode is avoided.

Summary

In the circuit	What to do
resistors and current sources	KCL at every non-ground node: $Y_n\mathbf{e} = \mathbf{i}_s$, from three simple rules; $Y_n = A_R G A_R^T$ is symmetric
a voltage source from the ground to node k	$e_k = v_s$ is known; no KCL at node k
a voltage source between two nodes	Method I: its current as an unknown, plus the constraint; Method II: KCL at the supernode, plus the constraint
a dependent source	write its control variable with node voltages: a constraint equation
the choice of ground	any node; the branch voltages and currents do not change

After the node voltages are found: $\mathbf{v} = A^T\mathbf{e}$, then the branch currents from the element laws.